Jingling High School

A Literature Review about What Effects Do Academic Rankings Have to Students' Academic Performance, Mental Health and Ability in Communication in Society

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2025/6/16

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Abstract

It is a popular saying that Chinese parents and students especially obsessed in school rankings (Li, K. 2021). With such large scope of using in school ranking in China, what specific effects does academic rankings effect with student's academic performance and mental health? Are there more benefits or disadvantages to students brought by academic rankings? It is hoped that through this literature review, the effects by academic ranking to student's academic performance and mental health could be understood and ranking could be appropriately utilized in the future education.

Context

Among resources, whether rankings in schools about students' academic performances bring more benefits or negative effect is a controversial topic. Students with high positions or are able to increase their position may feel proud and honored, while the ones who fall behind could feel way more distress and have the thought of giving up. There is different elaboration about academic rankings in different perspectives like mental fitness, social collaboration and self-esteem of students.

School rankings could play a role as a motivator in studying, students will strive to get to a higher position (Lee, Y., & Ruckman, A., 2022). It is also believed that a accurate ranking in school could help admission officer in college and universities to

determine whether a student could be offered an admission by the ranking (Ivy Coach.). Showing the ranking of the students at school also makes their position and progress transparent, which will help them gain confidence and self-esteem once they get an improvement (Delaney, J. M., & Devereux, P. J. 2022). It is all shown that ranking in academic performance could benefit students and teachers in many different ways. Students could achieve success in academic performances if the ranking is utilized in an appropriate way.

There are still negative effects if the academic ranking is overused or students care about it too much. For the competing with others in rankings, it will easily cause distress to students, which could cause mental health issues (White, L., 2023). Those competitive effects don't only effects on the individuals, but the social connection among them and their friends. According to Walter's article, it is possible that for the competitive and serious environment, the relationship between students may become hostile and indifferent, they will be unwilling to collaborate with each other (Walters, C., 2025). It will make the students lack of people to confide their stress and make more damages when there are mental health problems. Students may focus too much about the ranking and their grades, while forgetting to explore their true interest and make their life monotonous (Guery, G., 2023). It is also worried that ranking could associated with self-fulfilling theory and influence individual's performance in academic areas while teachers or others may treat the students differently according to the ranking (Wong, Yew Choe, 2006). Generally speaking, although ranking could motivate students to learn better, it is inevitable that academic rankings could bring

indifferent relationships, overly stress and biased treatment.

In future studies, research into effects academic ranking made to the whole educational environment is essential, including its lack of equality, the gaming in the system and the diversity and pressure caused to the individuals (Hazelkorn, E., 2025). Furthermore, in order to reduce the negative effects, it is necessary to explore methods and educational strategies for parents and schools to utilize the academic ranking in a positive and appropriate way. A strategy with less pressure to students and could encourage them do their best in academic activities is needed.

Methodology

To study the topic of "Academic ranking's effects to students grade and mental health," a combination of qualitative and quantitative research is necessary. The most important part of the researches is to find out whether it brings stress and pressure to students since over high stress levels could lead to poor academic performance and impaired mental health. Quantitative researches could include measurement in body rates like specific hormones. Measuring the cortisol levels could help show the state of stress (National Academies Press, 2025). Moreover, measuring the level of Depressive symptoms (CES-D) by scales in surveys could also help find out the level of stress (Norris, J). Qualitative analysis like surveys is vital as well, self-surveying scale designed by Putri is a great choice to show how much stress and mental issues an individual have (Putri, L. A, 2024).

The mix of comparative analysis and cross-sectional study is necessary in

exploring the topic. By comparing the mental fitness and the academic performances of people who are experiencing an academic ranking and people who are not, it is possible to accurately find out whether the ranking causes more positive effects or negative ones and could find out the traits that cause the issues. By studying the traits, it is also possible to acquire a solution to appropriately use the academic rankings. Experiments with independent variables of whether or not there exist examinations and rankings for students, and dependent variables as the outcomes from Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale or GAD-7, PHQ-9 to see the difference of depression levels, anxiety levels and self-esteem (Rosenberg, Morris., 1965) (Williams, N., 2014a) (Williams, N., 2014b). Studies to find out the degree of using the ranking and forming a better harmonious environment in school is also necessary.

Impact as motivation and provide eustress

Students could see where they are in the school transparently, they may have a clear goal and work more for a higher position. According to the researches, a clear aim to students is significantly important to their own academic development (Konrad, M. et al., 2014). Students may feel honored and confident when they see themselves made progress. The confidence and self-esteem could definitely help students have interest in learning and being better. Self-confidence in students is positively significantly correlated to their learning process (Akbari, O., & Sahibzada, J., 2025). With a clear aim and a positive mentality, it is possible for students to have the motivation to strive to a novel and better level in academic performance. As soon as

they receive honor like having a progress or staying in a very high position in the ranking, it will make students even want to improve more. Students are likely to perform better in their disciplines if they receive more honors at school (Seager, K. et al., 2012). In conclusion, it is shown that many of the products ranking provide to students like confidence and a clear target benefits the students' academic performance.

Furthermore, it is not necessary to motivate students only if the students make a progress, when they perform not good enough, it still could help the students learn in their failure. It is shown that the dissatisfaction of current situations of citizens will lead to more responsibilities and more work to improve the whole society, which is the motivation provided by the sense of crisis (Crayne, M. P., & Medeiros, K. E., 2021). It works the same for students that if a student has a bad grade that makes him dissatisfied, he may feel anxious and the eustress created in pressure could motivate him to work better and achieve to the original position or even higher. According to the General Adaptation Syndrome (GAS) model, it is possible for students to try to act better when feeling threat and anxious in studies, but it is based on the perception of the students (Kupriyanov, R., & Zhdanov, R., 2014). Thus, the help of ranking to the students is irreplaceable and extremely important, it is unrealistic to get rid of the whole academic ranking system to solve the problems on students' mental health.

Negative impact on providing distress and collaboration problems among students

As mentioned above, the motivation and the positive effect to students' academic performances based on individual's own perception. When students see the ranking with too much weight, the excessive stress brought by rankings will lead to unexpected outcomes. There are plenty of negative effect to students who take on too much stress and consider themselves as a competing individual when being ranked. Distress, which is overly stressed out, could have negative effect to university students in academic performance (Sharp, J., & Theiler, S., 2018). The article also shows that the negative outcome could also be cause by students being alone, which is not collaborating with others (2018). Students may experience too much stress and work even worse when they find their ranking have been lower than before (Viertiö, S., et al., 2021). It is possible that the system of ranking in academic performances could stop the students from improving and having more setbacks from the students' positions in the ranking.

For the perception of communicating, the research by Sharp also mentioned that the poor academic performance could also be cause by students being alone, which is not collaborating with others (2018). Being alone and lack of communication with others could be considered to bring poor ability in managing depression and the capability of expressing oneself clearly, which leads to poor performances. Researches found that collaboration among peers is extremely vital since we could learn things and experiences, it could also reduce negative emotions (Mattessich, P. W., & Monsey, B. R., 1992). It is also found that loneliness could make individuals have more depression symptoms, be afraid of elaboration in society and communities

and be afraid of trying (Heinrich, L. M., & Gullone, E., 2006). In general, many students will take the ranking system in school with too much stress, it not only causes apparent issues like failing grades, but also negative impact in mental health and social abilities. It is necessary to take action to avoid students taking the ranking too serious. Possible actions like setting some privacy in the system and make clearance of the students necessary for checking their rankings.

Proposed research

In order to explore the effects that caused by academic rankings, the purposed research should include a variety of mixed methods. It is necessary to have quantitative data analysis among results in surveys that students report if they experience school ranking and light scale about how they feel. Objective measurements about their biological body changes correlated to students' current situation, emotion and mental health could also achieve the purpose exploring the effects of ranking on students. Longitudinal studies and cross-sectional studies are both suggested. Experiments controlling independent variables of having ranking or not is also vital in the topic.

The sample should be students in different cultures and in different levels of education. It is also necessary to have longitudinal studies which have a time interval of a semester or more. Which could help to understand further impact on students formed by the rankings in schools. And since there is a risk of mental issues for the students, also it is important to keep the students unknown about anything during the

research, it is necessary to include more stricter ethical considerations in the future studies. Inform consent from parents and debriefing to students after the research should be considered. Through the research above, the effects could be explained in details, and the academic ranking could be used in an appropriate and scientific way, while it could bring more benefits to students and reduce the negative impacts.

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